

MILESTONES**NUCLEAR PHYSICS**

Enrolls at Berkeley in 1936; obtains her PhD in 1940, and gains experience in nuclear physics.

VITAL WORK

Carries out an experiment that disproves the theory of "conservation of parity" as a universal law in 1956.

RECEIVES HONORS

Accepts National Medal of Science in 1975; becomes first female president of American Physical Society.

Chinese American nuclear physicist Chien-Shiung Wu, a female trailblazer in the scientific world, gained international acclaim for disproving the universal nature of a fundamental law of physics.

Chien-Shiung Wu moved from China to the US to study in 1936. She earned her PhD in nuclear physics from the University of California, Berkeley, where her work included splitting uranium atoms to create radioactive isotopes. Wu then began teaching at Princeton as the institute's first female lecturer before moving in 1944 to work on the Manhattan Project (working toward the atomic bomb) at the University of Columbia, where she helped develop radiation detectors and Geiger counters. In 1956, she carried out the Wu Experiment, which resulted in her major contribution to science. It demonstrated that a fundamental principle of physics (conservation of parity) is not universally valid. This principle was believed to govern the behavior of all subatomic particles until Wu's experiment proved it did not apply in all situations. She won global acclaim for her discovery and helped secure a Nobel Prize for fellow physicists Yang Chen-Ning (see p.284) and Tsung-Dao Lee, whose theory she confirmed.

"This **wonder** ... can be the reward of a lifetime."

Chien-Shiung Wu, 1957

**CHIEN-SHIUNG
WU**

